

miss any opportunities that arose, even failing to see significant action during the War with Mexico in 1846–48. He performed administrative roles on shore, supervising ordnance at the Navy Yard at Norfolk, Virginia, and organized the founding of the Mare Island Navy Yard in California.

War breaks out

When Farragut offered his services to the Union in April 1861, turning his back on his Southern roots, there was no reason to believe he would become an exceptional leader. For eight months he languished without significant employment, partly because of suspicion of his Southern origins, until Secretary of the Navy Gideon Welles selected him to command the naval attack on New Orleans.

Farragut's new role placed him in charge of the West Gulf Blockading Squadron in early 1862, and he immediately showed skills that were to be repeated in other operations. Although the original plan for the attack on New Orleans had been a land assault supported by the navy, Farragut largely ignored the army's role, preferring to do the job on his own. He was meticulous and unhurried in his preparations, but then carried out the attack on the Mississippi River defenses with resolution and aggression. When his flagship, USS *Hartford*, was set on fire, he responded with admirable calmness and inspired his crew to bring the blaze under control.

The bold manner of the capture of New Orleans earned Farragut fame, promotion, and the thanks of Congress. The United States had previously scorned the term admiral, according instead the more "democratic" rank of flag officer to its senior naval commanders, but Farragut was made a rear admiral to general acclaim.